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Validation Protocol Review Checklist

A structured quality review tool for qualification and validation protocol readiness

Use this checklist before protocol approval or execution to confirm that scope, prerequisites, risk rationale, test methods, acceptance criteria, data handling, deviations and final disposition requirements are clear, traceable and scientifically justified.

Resource code	VSR-VAL-CHK-005	**Version**	9.0
Issue date	October 2026	**Primary basis**	EU GMP Annex 15; ICH Q9(R1); FDA Process Validation guidance, where applicable
Applicability	Qualification and validation protocols for facilities, equipment, utilities, processes and related studies; adapt to approved site procedures and study scope.		

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IMPORTANT USE NOTE
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1. Document control, ownership and approvals

Confirm the protocol is controlled, identifiable and approved by the appropriate functions before execution.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
1	Protocol title, unique identifier, version and effective/approval status are clearly defined.		
2	Protocol owner, author, reviewer(s) and approver(s) are identified with roles consistent with the QMS.		
3	Applicable site, area, equipment/system/process and study type are unambiguous.		
4	Revision history or change rationale is documented where the protocol replaces or revises an earlier version.		
5	Required QA/Quality oversight is defined and approval is completed before execution unless an approved procedure permits otherwise.		
6	Controlled-copy, issuance and archival expectations are defined or governed by an approved document-control procedure.		
7	Electronic protocol systems, if used, are governed by applicable validated-system and access-control requirements.		

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2. Scope, objective and intended use

A protocol should state exactly what is being demonstrated and what is outside the study boundary.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
8	Objective states the qualification/validation purpose and the decision the study is intended to support.		
9	Scope defines inclusions, exclusions, boundaries, interfaces and operating modes relevant to the study.		
10	Intended use and GMP impact are described for equipment, utilities, systems or processes under qualification.		
11	Product, process, system or equipment configuration is identified with sufficient specificity to avoid ambiguity.		
12	Where bracketing, matrixing or representative configurations are used, the rationale is documented and scientifically justified.		
13	Assumptions and limitations that may affect interpretation of results are stated.		
14	The protocol aligns with the Validation Master Plan, project validation plan or equivalent lifecycle strategy where applicable.		

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3. References, prerequisites and readiness

Execution should begin only when prerequisite information, controls and supporting systems are ready and traceable.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
15	Applicable SOPs, specifications, drawings, URS, risk assessments, design documents and prior qualification records are correctly referenced.		
16	Reference document numbers and revisions are current or their applicability is justified.		
17	Required utilities, environmental conditions and supporting systems are available and in an appropriate state.		
18	Instruments and measuring devices required for execution are identified and within calibration status.		
19	Required preventive maintenance, installation completion, commissioning or engineering turnover prerequisites are defined.		
20	Personnel executing or reviewing the study have applicable training/qualification requirements defined.		
21	Outstanding punch-list items, deviations or project actions are assessed for impact before protocol execution.		
22	Required materials, standards, loads, challenge items or test articles are identified and suitable for use.		

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4. Risk rationale and criticality

The extent of testing should be justified using knowledge of intended use, critical aspects and quality risk.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
23	A documented risk assessment or equivalent rationale supports the scope and depth of testing.		
24	Critical quality attributes, critical process parameters, critical functions or critical aspects are identified where applicable.		
25	Risk controls being verified by the protocol are traceable to specific tests or acceptance criteria.		
26	High-risk failure modes or critical conditions receive adequate challenge and objective evidence.		
27	Risk-based reductions, leveraged testing or supplier evidence are justified and documented.		
28	Known uncertainties and assumptions are considered in the test strategy.		
29	The testing approach is proportionate to patient, product, process and data-integrity risk.		

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5. Test methodology and challenge design

Each test should be executable, reproducible and capable of generating objective evidence against a predefined requirement.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
30	Each test has a clear purpose linked to a requirement, risk control or acceptance decision.		
31	Stepwise test instructions are sufficiently detailed to allow consistent execution without undocumented interpretation.		
32	Test inputs, operating conditions, set points, loads, configurations and challenge conditions are defined.		
33	Normal operating ranges and applicable upper/lower or worst-case conditions are appropriately challenged.		
34	Required sampling locations, sample quantities, frequencies and timing are predefined.		
35	Test equipment, tools, software, instruments or data sources needed for execution are identified.		
36	Expected evidence such as printouts, trends, screenshots, raw data or attachments is specified where appropriate.		
37	Retesting or repeat-testing rules are governed by approved procedures and are not used to replace unexplained failing data.		

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6. Acceptance criteria and decision rules

Acceptance criteria should be objective, predefined and scientifically or procedurally justified before data are generated.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
38	Acceptance criteria are measurable, unambiguous and directly linked to the requirement or risk being verified.		
39	Specifications, limits, tolerances or pass/fail rules are referenced to approved sources.		
40	Acceptance criteria are not written as subjective statements such as “satisfactory” without objective definition.		
41	Alert/action limits, statistical criteria or variability expectations are distinguished from formal acceptance criteria where applicable.		
42	Where no numerical specification exists, the qualitative decision rule and supporting rationale are explicit.		
43	Any use of vendor limits, engineering tolerances or development data is justified for GMP qualification/validation use.		
44	Criteria for overall protocol acceptance and study disposition are defined.		

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7. Data recording, traceability and integrity

The protocol should create a complete and reviewable evidence trail from requirement through execution and conclusion.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
45	Data-entry fields are adequate for actual values, observations, initials/signatures, dates and supporting evidence references.		
46	Requirements can be traced to tests and resulting evidence using a matrix, test reference or equivalent method.		
47	Raw data sources are identified, attributable and retained according to approved procedures.		
48	Manual transcriptions, calculations and conversions include appropriate verification or review controls.		
49	Electronic data, audit trails and metadata are retained where relevant to the GMP decision.		
50	Attachments are uniquely identified and cross-referenced to the applicable test step.		
51	Blank, unused or not-applicable fields are handled in accordance with Good Documentation Practice.		
52	Data corrections and changes during execution are attributable, legible and appropriately justified.		

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8. Deviations, exceptions and change control

The protocol must define how unexpected events are documented and how their impact on study validity is assessed.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
53	Deviation handling requirements and references to the applicable procedure are stated.		
54	Protocol exceptions, test failures or unexpected results require documented investigation and impact assessment.		
55	The protocol distinguishes execution comments from deviations that require formal quality-system handling.		
56	Any change to approved test steps, acceptance criteria or study scope requires appropriate authorization before implementation.		
57	Open deviations or actions are evaluated for impact on protocol conclusion and release decisions.		
58	Retesting or re-execution is scientifically justified, traceable to the original result and appropriately approved.		
59	Changes discovered during qualification/validation are assessed for impact on requirements, risk and validated state.		

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9. Sampling, statistics and representativeness

Where sampling or statistical methods are used, the protocol should explain why the plan is sufficient to support the intended conclusion.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
60	Sampling plan identifies population, locations, quantities, frequency and selection method where applicable.		
61	Number of runs, cycles, batches, loads or repetitions is justified based on process knowledge, risk and study objective.		
62	Worst-case or representative conditions are identified using documented technical rationale.		
63	Statistical methods, calculations and software are predefined where they influence acceptance decisions.		
64	Data exclusions or outlier handling are governed by predefined procedures and scientific justification.		
65	Trend, variability and reproducibility expectations are considered where relevant to the study.		

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10. Completion, reporting and lifecycle linkage

The protocol should clearly define what happens after execution and how the validated/qualified state will be maintained.

ID	Review point	Y / N / N.A.	Evidence / comment / action
66	Completion requirements include review of all tests, attachments, deviations, calculations and unresolved actions.		
67	Protocol summary or final report requirements are defined, including conclusion and acceptance status.		
68	Responsibility for final technical review and Quality approval is identified.		
69	Release/use restrictions are defined where the system or process cannot be used before final acceptance.		
70	Follow-up actions, residual risks or limitations are documented and assigned to accountable owners.		
71	Requalification, periodic review, continued/ongoing verification or monitoring requirements are identified where applicable.		
72	Change-control triggers that could affect the qualified or validated state are recognized.		
73	Records generated by the study are retained according to the applicable record-retention system.		

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Final Protocol Review Disposition

Use this section to summarize the pre-approval review outcome and any actions required before execution.

Review outcome	[ ] Approved for execution [ ] Approved with actions [ ] Revision required before approval
Critical gaps identified	
Open actions / owners	
Required completion date	
Reviewer name / function	
Review date	

Priority Action Tracker

No.	Action / gap	Owner	Target	Status
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

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Reference Basis & Use Guidance

This resource is designed as a practical review aid. It should be adapted to the applicable product, process, system, facility, study type and approved quality-system procedures.

Reference	How it informs this checklist
EU GMP Annex 15 - Qualification and Validation	Lifecycle qualification/validation expectations, planning, documentation, risk-based scope, qualification stages, process validation, requalification and change control.
ICH Q9(R1) - Quality Risk Management	Science- and risk-based decision-making; formality and documentation should be commensurate with risk and uncertainty.
FDA - Process Validation: General Principles and Practices	Lifecycle approach to process validation, including process design, process qualification and continued process verification.
EU GMP Annex 11 - Computerised Systems, where applicable	Relevant where computerized systems or electronic records are part of the validation evidence or system under review.

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